A.
Title: Player Data and Metagaming in League of Legends
Topic: While video game data collection can be seen as surveillance, players often use this data in the form of third-party applications to gain competitive advantages which forces developers (the vectoralist class) to restrict data access.

Thesis: Even though third-party applications allow League of Legends players to use data for a competitive advantage, Riot Games still holds the power because it controls the API and can decide what information players and third-party developers are allowed to access.

B.
1. I. Background
In ranked League of Legends, third-party applications such as OP.GG previously allowed players to see their teammates performance statistics during champion selection, encouraging players to lobby dodge and to use the data for other types of metagaming.

II. Thesis
Even though third-party applications allow League of Legends players to use data for a competitive advantage, Riot Games still holds the power because it controls the API and can decide what information players and third-party developers are allowed to access.

III. Arguments

A. Third-party applications transform player data into a competitive edge against others.
   a. Applications such as OP.GG use Riot's API to organize statistics including match histories, win rates, champion experience, and recent performance. (OP.GG)
      i. Access to this information allows players to judge teammates before a match and decide whether to dodge, change champions, or pressure another player to do something.
   b. This creates a form of metagaming where winning can depend not only on mechanical skill, but also on using outside information for decisions such as counterpicking, judging teammates before the game starts, and choosing whether to dodge.
      i. Mastery of the mechanical aspects of these games is not always enough to guarantee competitive success if a player is to maximize his or her chances of victory in ranked play, metagame expertise must be acquired. (Donaldson, 2017)

B. Riot Games response shows us an example of the "vectoralist class"
      i. Wark defined the vectoralist class as "The ascendant power over both labor and capital is the vectoralist class. It does not control land or industry anymore, just information" (Wark, 2015)
   b. Riot owns and controls the servers, API, game client, and how player information is collected and used.

c. Patch 12.22 anonymized most teammates during ranked champion selection because Riot opposed having players metagaming through lobby information and pressuring others to dodge. (Riot Games) (Wark, 2015)
    i. The change shows that players and third-party developers can use game information only when Riot allows them to do so

C. The API system creates an unequal relationship between players, third-party application developers, and Riot
  a. Players create data through their matches but have limited control over how that data is collected, stored, and used.
    i. This shows Ouellette and Gray's idea of the "big data divide" because players have little to no influence over how their information is collected and used.
    ii. "For example, Riot Games… provides an extensive application programming interface (API) containing practice (e.g., frequency and duration of matches) and performance (e.g., kills, deaths, and assists) data for all players engaged in ranked matchmaking play." (Bennett, 2025)
    iii. This also applies to the developers of the third-party applications like [OP.GG](OP.GG) and others.
      1. Third-party developers are dependent on Riot because Riot controls their access to the API which they require.
  b. Ouellette and Gray's description of the "big data divide"
    i. a "big data divide" is emerging, where individuals have little chance to influence the terms upon which their information is gathered and used. (Ouellette, 2017)

Image:

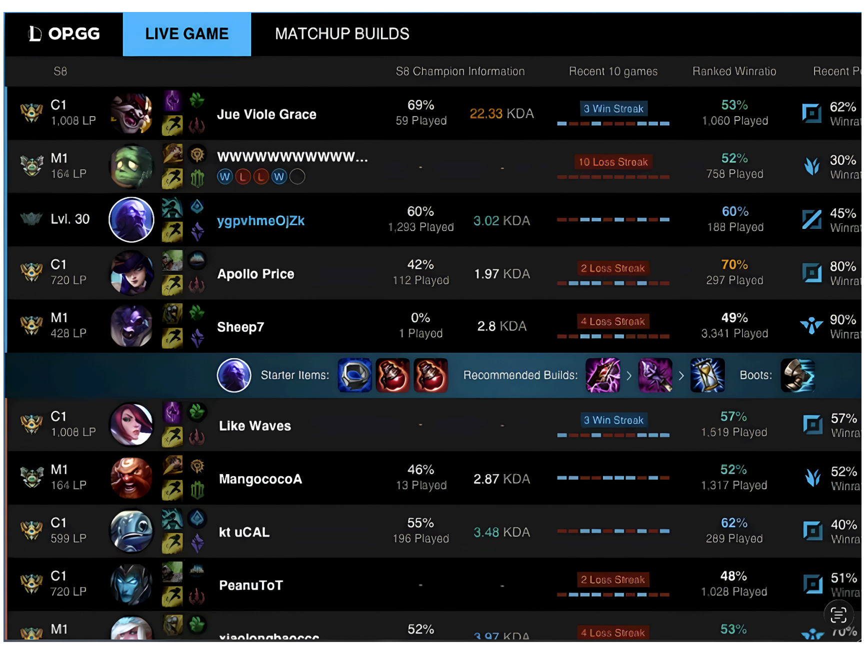

Figure 1. OP.GG Overwolf overlay showing data about teammates, opponents, win streaks, and more. (OP.GG before patch 12.22)

IV. Counter arguments

a. Some people might argue that giving players access to the game API actually gives the community power and could improve the game experience.
   i. One example could be Destiny 2, the community uses the API to make things like third-party inventory managers and apps for importing builds which end up being way better than the systems actually in the game (DIM)
b. While this does let players have more freedom and potentially improve the game experience, this power is still conditional because the developers still have the final say and can shut it down or change it whenever they want, so the developers still have the power.

V. Conclusion

a. This League of Legends example shows that making player data available does not necessarily give players control over it. Developers still decide how the data can be accessed and used, so they should be more transparent about what information they collect and when they may restrict access to it.

C. References

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